Ayesha Ahmed

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+1 (530) 220-3842 Davis, CA 95616, USA

Education

University of California, Davis — Davis, CA
Ph.D. in Agricultural and Resource Economics — 2027 (expected)
Dissertation: Repayment Incentives and Non-Price Credit Rationing in Microfinance

University of Dhaka — Dhaka, Bangladesh
M.S.S. in Economics *(top 2% of graduating class)* — 2019
B.S.S. in Economics *(top 1% of graduating class)* — 2018

Research Fields

Primary: Development Economics, Behavioral & Experimental Economics, Credit Markets & Risk Management
Secondary: Agricultural Economics

Dissertation Committee

Prof. Michael R. Carter (Chair)
University of California, Davis
Distinguished Professor of Agricultural and Resource Economics
mrcarter@ucdavis.edu

Prof. Stephen R. Boucher
University of California, Davis
Associate Professor of Agricultural and Resource Economics
srboucher@ucdavis.edu

Prof. Anujit Chakraborty
University of California, Davis
Associate Professor of Economics
chakraborty@ucdavis.edu

Working Papers and Research in Progress

Ahmed, A. 2026. "Audience Effect in Microfinance: Does Social Observability of Default Increase Repayment?" Job Market Paper. Draft | Slides

Mahzab, M., **Ahmed, A.**, Brooks, N., Mahajan, A., Luby, S., Biswas, D., Ahmed, R., and Ahmed, S. 2026. "When Corruption Is the Norm: Can Signaling Environmental Compliance Reduce Bribery?" Draft | Slides

Amin, M. D., **Ahmed, A.**, and Badruddoza, S. 2026. "Minimum Wages and Consumer Demand: Evidence from U.S. Fast-Food Chains."

Ahmed, A. 2026. "Repayment Motivations and Financial Behaviors in Microfinance: Do Experimental Measures Predict Field Decisions?"

Carter, M., **Ahmed, A.**, and Das, N. C. 2026. "Indexed Financial Tools and Risk Rationing in Microfinance."

Ahmed, A. 2026. "Measuring Non-Price Credit Rationing in Microfinance."

Research Experiences

University of California, Davis — Davis, CA
Graduate Student Researcher for Prof. Michael Carter — Aug 2022–Present

- Randomized controlled trial on indexed financial tools among smallholder farmers (ongoing).
- Lab-in-the-field experiment on the audience effect in microfinance.
- Direct elicitation of non-price credit rationing among microfinance borrowers.

BRAC Institute of Governance and Development (BIGD) — Dhaka, Bangladesh
Research Associate for Dr. Narayan Das — Aug 2020–Aug 2021

- Impact evaluation of skill development programme for disadvantaged youth.
- Chapter on youth migration for BRAC's Urban Development Program.

BRAC James P. Grant School of Public Health — Dhaka, Bangladesh
Research Assistant for Dr. Zahidul Quayyum — Feb 2020–Jul 2020

- Policy report on Bangladesh's health system response to COVID-19.
- Social return on investment of BRAC's Health, Nutrition, and Population Program.

Bangladesh Institute of Development Studies (BIDS) Dhaka, Bangladesh
Research Assistant for Dr. Mainul Hoque Aug 2019–May 2020

- Price volatility index using large datasets of agricultural commodity prices.
- Empirical and GIS analysis for research on crop diversification trends in Bangladesh.

University of Dhaka, Department of Economics Dhaka, Bangladesh
Research Assistant for Prof. Sayema Haque Sep 2019–Dec 2019

- Gender responsive budget report for the Ministry of Health and Family Welfare.

Teaching Experiences

University of California, Davis Davis, CA

Teaching Assistant: Econometrics for Business Decisions, Econometric Theory & Applications, Intermediate Microeconomics, Corporate Finance

Guest Lectures: Introduction to Applied Research Methods (PhD): Experimental protocols and findings from fieldwork in Bangladesh; Designing and implementing lab-in-the-field experiments; Senior Research Thesis: Preparing and presenting conference posters

Grants, Fellowships, and Awards

Jastro & Shields Graduate Research Award ($3,000)	UC Davis 2026
ARE Summer Research Fellowship (total $4,500)	UC Davis 2024, 2026
ARE Graduate Travel Award ($1,250)	UC Davis 2025
Subgrant, Resilience+ Innovation Facility ($30,740)	UC Davis 2024
First-Year Summer Fellowship ($5,000)	UC Davis 2021
Shamsun Nahar Mahmud Foundation Merit Award	University of Dhaka 2019
Governor's Scholarship	University of Dhaka 2015-2017

Conference Presentations

Northeastern Universities Development Consortium (NEUDC); Development Workshop at UC Davis; AAEA Annual Meeting, MO; Symposium in Honor of Michael Carter; Pacific Conference for Development Economics (PacDev) (presented by coauthor)	2026
AAEA & WAEA Joint Annual Meeting, CO (Poster); 14th Annual Bay Area Behavioral Economics and Experimental Workshop	2025
Fourth SANEM–World Bank North America Discussion Forum, Washington, DC	2023
15th South Asian Economics Students' Meet, World Bank, Colombo (Best Paper); 4th SANEM Annual Economists' Conference, Dhaka	2019
14th South Asian Economics Students' Meet, World Bank, Bangladesh; 1st Bangladesh Economics Summit, University of Dhaka (Best Paper); Speakonomics at EconFest, North South University (Best Paper)	2018

Professional Service

Session Moderator, AAEA Annual Meeting, 2026; Reviewer, Pacific Conference for Development Economics, 2026; Student Organizer, Development Tea, Spring Quarter 2024

Technical Skills

Programming: Python, R, Stata, Julia, SQL

Tools & Platforms: VS Code, Jupyter, LaTeX, Git/GitHub, ArcGIS, SurveyCTO

Languages: Bangla (native), English (fluent), Spanish (intermediate), Hindi (intermediate)

Abstracts

Ahmed, A., "Audience Effect in Microfinance: Does Social Observability of Default Increase Repayment?", (2026); *Job Market Paper*

Does making default observable to peers increase repayment in individual liability microfinance? I study this question in a framed lab-in-the-field experiment with 919 agricultural borrowers across 100 borrowing groups in Bangladesh, varying whether default is observable to peers for a hypothetical microfinance loan. The within-subject design identifies the audience effect on repayment. I find that an audience raises repayment by 3.3 to 5.3 percent relative to repayment without an audience, with no detectable variation across income states. The conceptual framework interprets repayment without an audience as reflecting intrinsic motivation and the additional repayment induced by an audience as reflecting reputational motivation. A reduction in field default of the same magnitude would raise lender profit by 34 to 55 percent of the zero-default margin.

Mahzab, M., Ahmed, A., Brooks, N., Mahajan, A., Luby, S., Biswas, D., Ahmed, R., and Ahmed, S., "When Corruption Is the Norm: Can Signaling Environmental Compliance Reduce Bribery?" (2026).

This paper studies whether credible signaling of regulatory compliance can reduce illicit payments in the brick kiln industry in Bangladesh. We exploit variation in banner display induced by randomized assignment to a broader environment friendly technology intervention and use the intervention as an instrument to identify the effect of compliance signaling. The banner signals both higher profitability and environmental compliance and the conceptual framework shows that its net effect on rent extraction depends on officials' preferences over their relative values. Empirically, the latter effect dominates and each additional week of banner display lowers bribe payments by 18.6 percent and compliance costs by 5.4 percent.

Amin, M. D., Ahmed, A., and Badruddoza, S., "Minimum Wages and Consumer Demand: Evidence from U.S. Fast-Food Chains." (2026).

This study examines how minimum wage regulation affects consumer spending and store revenue in the U.S. fast-food industry. Using a triple differences (DDD) design, we exploit variation across states, over time, and between chains covered and not covered by California's fast-food minimum wage law (AB 1228). The analysis uses a high frequency panel of 680,000+ store-level sales and customer traffic, with data processing and analysis implemented in Python.

Ahmed, A., "Repayment Motivations and Financial Behaviors in Microfinance: Do Experimental Measures Predict Field Decisions?" (2026).

This study develops individual-specific measures of intrinsic and reputational motivations for repayment from repeated choices in a framed lab-in-the-field experiment with microfinance borrowers. A structural model is used to recover borrower-specific behavioral parameters from censored repayment choices, using random-effects Tobit and two-limit Tobit specifications while accounting for measurement error in the recovered parameters. The resulting measures are then used to examine whether experimentally elicited repayment motivations predict subsequent field outcomes, including insurance uptake and non-price credit rationing.

Carter, M., Ahmed, A., and Das, N. C., "Indexed Financial Tools and Risk Rationing in Microfinance." (2026).

This study examines whether indexed financial tools reduce risk rationing among smallholder microfinance borrowers in Bangladesh. Through a large-scale randomized experiment with 6,683 farmers, we compare standalone agricultural index insurance with insurance bundled with savings and a contingent line of credit, and estimate their effects on different forms of non-price credit rationing. We also examine whether risk rationing is more prevalent among borrowers who are more responsive to reputational incentives, testing whether social collateral discourages borrowing under risk.

Ahmed, A., "Measuring Non-Price Credit Rationing in Microfinance." (2026).

This study measures the prevalence and composition of non-price credit rationing among microfinance borrowers in Bangladesh. We adapt the Direct Elicitation Method to the microfinance setting to distinguish borrowers who are quantity rationed, price rationed, or risk rationed. The resulting measures provide a framework for studying how borrower characteristics and exposure to risk shape credit demand and access.